HOW TO MAKE JERK CHICKEN AND RASTA PASTA

Preparation Time: About 2 hours

Jerk chicken and rasta pasta are two popular dishes from the Caribbean, especially Jamaica. They have gained worldwide popularity for their bold, spicy, and creamy flavors. Jerk chicken comes from a special Jamaican cooking style called "jerk." This method involves rubbing or marinating meat with a spicy mix of allspice, scotch bonnet peppers, thyme, and other seasonings before grilling or pan-frying. Rasta pasta has bright red, yellow, and green bell peppers that reflect the colors of the Rastafarian flag. It is a creamy, spicy pasta dish that goes well with the smoky heat of jerk chicken.

Unlike complicated restaurant recipes that need a charcoal grill and a marinade that takes days to prepare, this recipe is made for college students in small kitchens with basic equipment. You won't need fancy tools or hard-to-find ingredients. Store-bought jerk seasoning does most of the work for you, and the creamy pasta sauce cooks in the same skillet used for the chicken, meaning fewer dishes to clean.

This recipe guides you through each step, from safely handling raw chicken to checking when your pasta sauce has reached the right thickness. Most steps include helpful tips and photo guides, so you can see what your food should look like along the way. Even if you've never cooked a full meal from scratch before, following these instructions will help you bring the vibrant, satisfying flavors of the Caribbean right into your own kitchen without ordering expensive takeout.

SAFETY INFORMATION

DANGER: Raw chicken can carry harmful bacteria like salmonella. Wash your hands, cutting board, knife, and any surface that touches raw chicken with hot soapy water right after handling it. Do not let raw chicken juices touch other ingredients.

CAUTION: Hot oil can splatter when you add chicken to the pan. Place the chicken in gently using tongs; do not drop it from above.

CAUTION: Pot and pan handles get very hot. Use a pot holder or a dry towel to hold them. Never leave a hot pan unattended on the stove.

WARNING: The oven and baking sheet become extremely hot. Use oven mitts when removing the baking sheet.

WARNING: Do not leave the stove unattended while cooking on high heat. Oil can catch fire if overheated.

EQUIPMENT AND MATERIALS

- Cutting board
- Chef's knife
- A bowl or container
- Measuring spoons
- Measuring cups
- Oven
- A pan
- Pot for boiling pasta
- A big spoon
- 2 Tongs
- Lemon Juice
- Baking sheet

INGREDIENTS

For the jerk chicken:



- Chicken wings
- Jerk seasoning (store-bought is fine)
- Black pepper
- Jerk Barbeque Sauce

For the rasta pasta:

- Pasta of any shape
- Chicken breasts
- Beef smoked sausage
- Jerk Seasoning
- Olive Oil
- 1 red bell pepper
- 1 yellow bell pepper
- Heavy cream
- Grated Parmesan cheese, Cheddar cheese, and Mozzarella cheese
- Chicken Broth
- Butter
- Salt and black pepper

Suggestion: *you could use 1 green bell pepper, ½ small onion, 2 cloves garlic for more flavor*

Tip: *If you are lactose intolerant canned coconut milk can replace the heavy cream.*
Note: *More seasonings were used, but we are keeping these instructions simple.*

PREP AND MARINATE THE CHICKEN

WINGS



1. Rinse the chicken wings under cold water in its original packaging
2. Drain the water
3. Squeeze lemon juice on the chicken
4. Rinse wings again with water
5. Drain the water again
6. Pat the chicken dry with paper towels.
7. Sprinkle a generous of jerk seasoning evenly on both sides of the chicken.
8. Use your hands to rub the seasoning into the meat and disperse it evenly.



9. Cover packaging with paper towels
10. Let the chicken marinate in the refrigerator for at least 30 minutes

Note: *If you have a bowl to clean the chicken, please use that instead of the packaging.*
Note: *Patting the chicken dry helps the seasoning stick better and makes the skin crispier when baked*
Warning: *Too much jerk seasoning can overwhelm with the flavor profile making the chicken too spicy or salty.*
Tip*: If you have more time, letting the chicken sit for 1-2 hours will give it even more flavor.*

BREASTS



1. Repeat Steps 1-6 from the Wings section
2. Place cleaned chicken on a cutting board

3. Using a knife cut chicken breasts into small chunks/pieces
4. Repeat Steps 7-10





Reminder: *Wash your hands and the cutting board as you will need it to cut the peppers as handling raw chicken is dangerous, and the cross contamination can make you sick.*

PREP THE VEGETABLES

1. While the chicken marinates, wash the bell peppers with cold water
2. Cut the bell peppers in half
3. Remove the stems and white seeds inside.
4. Slice each pepper into thin strips
5. Cut the strips into small pieces about ½ inch wide.



COOK THE WINGS

1. Take the wings out of the refrigerator.
2. Preheat oven to 350 °F
3. Cover the baking sheet with aluminum foil





4. Place wings on baking sheet
5. Dump excess seasoning from packaging on wings





6. Place baking sheet in oven
7. Bake for 25-30 minutes

NOTE: While the chicken is baking go to the "Cooking Chicken Breasts and Smoked Sausage" section

Warning*: The baking sheet will be very hot. Use oven mitts every time you remove or return it to the oven.*



8. Remove the baking sheet from the oven
9. Using tongs flip wings over
10. Bake again for another 25-30 minutes on that side

NOTE: While the chicken is baking again go to the "Boiling the Pasta" and "Making the Rasta Pasta Sauce" sections.



11. Remove the baking sheet from the oven once again
12. Grab the Jerk Barbeque Sauce
13. Put the Barbeque Sauce in a bowl or container

14. Using tongs dip each chicken wing in the sauce making sure to cover both sides



15. Place each wing back on the baking sheet
16. Put baking sheet back in the oven for another 5-10 minutes

Tip: *For extra crispy wings, turn the oven to broil for the final 2-3 minutes, but watch closely so they don't burn.*



Cooking the Chicken Breasts and Smoked Sausage

1. Take the breasts out of the refrigerator.
2. Put the pan/skillet on the stove
3. Put the stove heat on high

Warning*: High heat can cause oil to splatter. Stand back slightly when adding food to the pan.*



4. Carefully place the chicken in the hot skillet with clean hands or tongs. (You should hear a sizzle.)



5. Add 1 tablespoon of olive oil to pan

6. Cook the chicken for 7-10 minutes



7. Using tongs flip the chicken
8. Continue cooking the chicken for another 7-10 minutes
9. Flip the chicken continuously every few minutes until all sides are browned



10. Place cooked chicken on a plate



11. Ensure the chicken is fully cooked by cutting into the thickest part.

Tip: *The inside should be white throughout with no pink. The juices should run clear.*

12. Add more chicken to the same pan
13. Repeat steps 6-9

14. While the chicken is cooking cut the sausage into bite size slices (about ½ inch thick)



15. Add a tablespoon of butter and the sausage to the same pan
16. Using tongs continuously mix for 5 minutes



17. Turn off the heat
18. Add the chicken and sausage to another plate

Note: *Please use a cutting board while cutting the sausage unlike what is seen in the image above.*

Tip*: Leaving a little bit of the chicken and sausage drippings in the pan adds more flavor to the sauce later.*

BOILING THE PASTA

1. Fill the pot with water, about ¾ full
2. Add a pinch of salt.
3. Place the pot on the stove.
4. Turn the heat to high (around setting 6 or 7)

Warning: *Do not leave boiling water unattended. It can boil over and cause burns or make a mess.*



5. Bring the water to a full boil, with big bubbles rising quickly.



6. Add the pasta to the boiling water.
7. Stir pasta once
8. Let the pasta boil for about 10 minutes.





9. Stir pasta occasionally
10. Turn off the heat.
11. Carefully drain the water in the sink.

Tip: *If you have a colander, use it. Draining pasta with a colander is much easier and faster, and you won't have to be as careful compared to tilting a heavy pot over the sink. Set the pasta aside.*

MAKING THE RASTA PASTA SAUCE

1. In the same skillet you used for the chicken, pour 500 mL of heavy cream
2. Add ½ cup cheddar cheese, ½ cup mozzarella cheese, and ½ cup Parmesan cheese.



3. Stir constantly with a spoon
4. Add a tablespoon of butter



5. Stir continuously until you get a slightly thick consistency.



6. Add all the chopped bell peppers.



7. Add a ½ cup of chicken broth
8. Continue to mix



9. Add your chicken and sausage
10. Continue to mix



11. Stir and cook for 3-4 minutes until the peppers soften slightly but still have some crunch.

Warning: *The sauce will be very hot. Be careful when tasting or stirring.*

Tip: *If the sauce becomes too thick, add a splash of pasta water or more chicken broth to thin it out.*

Tip: *If the sauce is too thin, let it simmer for an additional 5-10 minutes without a lid.*

COMBINE AND SERVE

1. Add the sauce to the pot with the pasta




2. Use a spoon to mix everything together until the pasta is coated in the sauce.



3. Place the jerk chicken wings on top of the pasta or off to the side.



4. Enjoy your homemade Caribbean food!

Tip: *If you have any vegetables on hand, serve them on the side. Steamed broccoli balances out the richness of the pasta and adds more nutrients to the meal.*

Note: *Make sure the oven and stove are turned off before you eat*

STORAGE AND LEFTOVERS

Store leftover rasta pasta and jerk chicken wings in separate sealed containers in the refrigerator for no more than 3 days. To reheat the pasta, microwave it for 1-2 minutes or warm it in a skillet over low heat with a splash of milk. For the wings, place them in an oven at 350°F for 5-10 minutes to make them crispy again. Avoid microwaving the wings, as they will turn soggy.

TROUBLESHOOTING

I've heard that washing chicken is not recommended by food safety experts, but this recipe includes washing steps. What should I do?

The USDA advises against washing raw chicken because splashing water can spread bacteria to your sink and countertops. However, many home cooks, particularly those making Caribbean dishes, like to wash chicken with lemon juice or vinegar. If you decide to wash your chicken, be very careful. Rinse it gently in a bowl or container. Immediately clean your sink and surrounding surfaces with hot, soapy water, and wash your hands thoroughly afterward. Both methods can be safe if you clean everything properly.

I don't have all the exact ingredients listed. What should I do?

This recipe is flexible. You can use any pasta shape you have. Any color of bell pepper is fine. If you don’t have jerk barbecue sauce, you can mix regular barbecue sauce with a little jerk seasoning.

RESOURCES FOR READERS

USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service. (2020, June 23). Chicken from farm to table. https://www.fsis.usda.gov/food-safety/safe-food-handling-and-preparation/poultry/chicken-farm-table

This government website provides detailed, research-backed guidelines on safely handling and cooking raw chicken. Covering safe minimum internal temperatures (165°F), proper storage times, and how to avoid cross-contamination in a home kitchen.

Michigan State University Extension. (2025, August 5). Master basic knife skills. https://www.canr.msu.edu/resources/mater-basic-knife-skills.

This university extension webpage provides clear, written instructions for basic knife skills that are perfect for beginner cooks. Covering workspace setup, proper knife grip (the pinch grip), the claw grip for protecting fingers while cutting, cutting board safety, and common knife cuts like slicing, dicing, chopping, and mincing.